Carla Coccia

University of Bern | carla.coccia@unibe.ch | ORCID

Development economist specializing in education and policy evaluation. Research on learning, school progression, and long-term outcomes in low- and middle-income countries using field experiments and innovative measurement approaches, including item response theory and machine learning, to improve the assessment and comparability of learning across contexts.

EDUCATION

PhD Economics (Education Policy & Development), University of Bern — 2021–2026
Advisor: Prof. Dr. Aymo Brunetti

Visiting Research Fellow, ITAM — 2023–2024
Advisor: Prof. Dr. Mauricio Romero

MSc in Applied Economic Analysis, University of Bern — 2019–2021
Special Qualification: International Development & Trade

BSc in Computing and Economics, University of Zurich — 2015–2018

EMPLOYMENT

Research Associate, Institute of Sociology, University of Bern — 2026–present
Design and implementation of randomized controlled trials (RCTs) in education, including field coordination, data collection, and scientific outputs

PhD Economics, Department of Economics, University of Bern — 2021–2026
Research in development and education economics; teaching, supervision, and student advising

Teacher (Part-time), Lernforum AG, Zurich — 2017–2021
Teaching preparatory courses for Gymnasium and Berufsmittelschule entrance exams and developing teaching materials

Research Assistant (Part-time), Immigration Policy Lab, ETH Zurich — 2019
Research on refugee immigration and migration policy in Italy and Spain

Web Application Developer Intern, RaiseNow AG, Zurich — 2017
Redesign of the company's e-payment API using PHP

Securities Specialist, UBS, Zurich — 2013–2014
Historical tax compliance processes related to UK–CH and Austria–CH agreements

WORK IN PROGRESS

Coccia, C., Prater, M., and Mosimann, J. (2026). *Teaching at the Low Level: Evidence on Direct Effects, Spillovers, and Parental Engagement in Remedial Education in El Salvador*. Working paper. doi:10.5281/zenodo.18623605

Coccia, C., Edmonds, E., Jakob, M., Romero, M. (2026). *Mentors or Messages? Experimental Evidence on Social Support, Information, and School Dropout in Rural Guatemala*. Working paper. Available at: link

Coccia, C., Jakob, M., Büchel, K., and Jann, B. (2026). *When Better Teachers Aren't Enough: An Experimental Evaluation of Teacher Training Programs in El Salvador*. Working paper. doi:10.5281/zenodo.18623393

Coccia, C. and Jakob, M. (2026). *Mobilizing for the Public Good: A Field Experiment on Community-Driven Development and Waste Management in El Salvador*. Working paper. Available at: link

Coccia, C., and Prater, M. (2026). *Improving Implementation at Scale: Experimental Evidence from a Government-Led TaRL Reform in El Salvador*. RCT implementation ongoing.

TEACHING

Lectures (TA)

Development Economics, Bachelor Level — 2022–2025
Teaching Assistant; guest lecture in 2023

Development Economics, Master Level — 2021

Global Economic Environment, Rochester/Bern Executive MBA Program — 2021–2025

Seminars

Seminar Development Economics, Master Level — 2021, 2024, 2025

Seminar Economic Policy, Bachelor Level — 2022–2025

Master Colloquium Applied Economic Analysis, Master Level — 2021–2026

Student Supervision

Advisor of Bachelor and Master Theses — 2021–2026

Supervision of Teaching Assistants — 2023–2026

FUNDING & GRANTS

Postdoc.Mobility Fellowship, Swiss National Science Foundation — 2026-2028
Fellowship at Paris School of Economics (CHF 122'000)

Unibe Research Foundation, University of Bern, with Ben Jann — 2026
Research Grant (CHF 25'500)

Educational Innovation Project, USAID, with Romero & Jakob — 2024
Evaluation grant for education interventions in El Salvador (USD 900,000)

Mobility Grant, University of Bern — 2023
Research stay at ITAM (CHF 30,000)

UniBE Short Travel Grant, University of Bern — 2023
Research stay at ITAM (CHF 3,630)

Root Causes of Irregular Migration in Guatemala, IOM, with Romero & Jakob — 2022
RCT on education and migration in Guatemala (USD 2.3M, cancelled during contract phase due to funding shortfalls at IOM)

AWARDS

Summa Cum Laude, University of Bern — 2026
Dissertation: "Essays in Experimental Development Economics and Education"

Third of Class, University of Bern — 2021
Third highest final grade among 98 social science graduates in 2021 (USD 600)

Outstanding Performance in the Swiss Matura, Kantonsschule Rychenberg — 2013
Recommendation for the Swiss Study Foundation for excellence in the Swiss Matura

INSTITUTIONAL TASKS

Student Advisor (M.A. Applied Economic Analysis), University of Bern — 2021–2026

SELECTED TRAINING

Winter School on Deep Learning, University of Bern — 2024

Deep Learning: Fundamentals and Applications, GSERM Summer School — 2023

Colloquium: Methods for Unstructured Data, University of Basel — 2021

OUTREACH

Co-organizer, Development Impact Happy Hour, Zurich/Bern 2024–2026
with Zurich Center for Economic Development & Coopération Globale; triannual event connecting researchers and practitioners

Talk "Insights into the QUEST Project", Consciente General Assembly 2025

Talk "Quantitative Policy Evaluation", State Secretariat for Economic Affairs 2023

CONFERENCES & SEMINARS

Invited Panelist, 8th Workshop on Experiments in Social Science Research 2026

Novafrica, Lisbon 2026

GDC, Kiel 2026

Bern Data Science Day, Bern 2026

EEA, Bordeaux 2025

GDC, Frankfurt 2025

ETH LELAM, Zurich 2024

Brown Bag CIE, ITAM 2023

SKILLS

Languages
German (native), Italian (native), English (proficient), Spanish (proficient), French (good)

Technical
R, Python, Stata, Java, PHP, Adobe InDesign

REFERENCES

Aymo Brunetti, University of Bern
aymo.brunetti@unibe.ch, +41 31 684 33 85

Mauricio Romero, ITAM
mtromero@itam.mx, +52 (55) 5628 4000

Ben Jann, University of Bern
ben.jann@unibe.ch, +41 31 684 48 31

Eric Edmonds, Dartmouth College
eric.edmonds@dartmouth.edu, +1 603-646-2944